

ABERI BALYA, A BISHOP LIKE NO OTHER

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TRANSLATING THE WORD OF GOD, SERVICE

Between 1910 and 1911, Balya joined forces with Reverends H.E. Maddox, Y. Kamuhigi and Z. Musana to take on a sacred mission: Translating the Bible into Runyoro-Rutooro.

By 1914, Balya's thirst for knowledge led him to Namirembe for a one-year course in ministry. From 1915 to 1918, he served in Rwengoma, Kabarole, shepherding his flock with patient grace and barefoot zeal. In 1918, under the tutelage of Bishop Alfred Tucker, he deepened his theological education and was ordained a deacon. Four years later, in 1922, he returned to Rwengoma, expanding his ministry into the remote hills of Bwamba, Bukonjo and Butuku.

After more training at Namirembe, he was ordained as a full reverend and by 1923, he was stationed at Rwano. A year later, he moved to Butiti-Kyenjojo, where he spent seven faithful years building churches, mentoring teachers and bringing hope to countless homes.

A FAREWELL PROMISE

In 1933, an emotional chapter unfolded. Balya travelled back to Mboga, Congo, this time to honour the dying wish of his dearest friend and fellow missionary, Reverend Apolo Kivebulaya. The two men had shared years of ministry and brotherhood, crossing borders for the Gospel. When Kivebulaya passed away, Balya made sure his final wish was fulfilled — to be buried in the Congo soil he had loved and served.

It was a journey of tears and tenderness — the barefoot bishop walking one last time beside his old comrade.

RECOGNITION AND HONOUR

Balya's years of service did not go unnoticed. In 1935, his dedication earned him the title of Canon at Namirembe Cathedral — a prestigious position for a man who once herded cattle and fled wars as a boy.

The same year, the Church Missionary Society of England recognised his exceptional work and invited him into their official hierarchy — a rare honour for an African clergyman at the time. By 1938, Balya was named an Honorary Life Governor of the Church Missionary Society, his name now etched alongside great



Bishop Balya (left) was ordained as a full reverend, and by 1923, he was stationed at Rwano

PLACES, INSTITUTIONS NAMED IN HONOUR OF BALYA

Across Uganda, the name Bishop Aberi Kakyomya Balya continues to echo not only in church hymns, but also on school walls, college gates, and city streets. His legacy has been etched into places of learning and worship that carry forward his spirit of faith, humility and service.

Institutions and landmarks named in his honour include:

- Bishop Balya Theological College – Bukuuku, Fort Portal
 - Bishop Balya Parish Church – Bunyonyi, Rwenzori Diocese
 - Bishop Balya Polytechnic – Bunyonyo, Kabarole
 - Balya House – Kyebambe Secondary School, Kabarole
 - Balya House – Nyakasura School, Kabarole
 - Balya House – Kicwamba Technical College, Kabarole
 - Balya House – Bweranyangi Girls Secondary School, Bushenyi
 - Balya House – Bishop Stuart College, Mbarara
 - Balya Road – Fort Portal City Municipality
- Each of these stands as a living monument to a man whose barefoot faith continues to inspire generations long after he left the pulpit.

missionaries of the age.

CONSECRATED BISHOP: THE RELUCTANT SHEPHERD WHO OBEYED THE CALL

By 1947, the barefoot preacher from Tooro had built a lifetime of faith, but heaven was not done with him yet. That year, the Church of England in Canterbury, London, reached across continents with a message that would shake his quiet humility: Reverend Balya was to be appointed assistant Bishop of Uganda, to serve alongside Bishop Stuart.

When the news came, Balya did not leap for joy. Quite the opposite. According to the Rev. Clovis Kyalimpa, who knew him well, the old man tried every holy excuse in the book to avoid the promotion. "He told me he pleaded with Bishop Stuart, saying he was too old and too unworthy for the position,"

Kyalimpa recalled with a smile. "Then he stood up, walked out of the room and slammed the door, hoping they would think he was too rebellious to be made bishop!" But heaven does not take "no" for an answer, especially from its chosen servants.

A DAY TO REMEMBER

The grand consecration took place on October 26, 1947, at Namirembe Cathedral. The Kabaka of Buganda, Sir Edward Mutesa, attended in person, joined by all the kings of Uganda and the Governor of Uganda himself.

From across Africa came high-ranking churchmen, Archbishop Morris of Sudan, Bishop Taylor of northern Rhodesia, the Bishop of Mombasa and many others. It was a moment when history, heaven and humanity converged under one vaulted roof. He was entrusted with

■ ON NOVEMBER 24, UGANDA CHRISTIAN UNIVERSITY- MUKONO (UCU) AND THE DIOCESE OF RWENZORI WILL HOST THE INAUGURAL BISHOP BALYA MEMORIAL LECTURE, WHICH WILL ALSO BE A FUNDRAISER TOWARDS THE BUILDING OF A LECTURE BLOCK AT BISHOP BALYA COLLEGE. BETWEEN NOVEMBER 24 AND 27, A SERIES OF FUNCTIONS ARE PLANNED IN FORT PORTAL.

the pastoral care of western Uganda and Mboga-Congo, though his spiritual reach extended across the entire nation, in consultation with Bishop Stuart.

FROM RELUCTANCE TO LEADERSHIP

When Bishop Stuart eventually retired, Balya too expressed his wish to lay down the mantle. But as always, the Lord had one more surprise in store.

Due to delays in the arrival of Bishop Brown, the newly appointed Archbishop of Uganda, Rwanda, Burundi and Boga-Congo, the Church found itself without a head. And so, the aging Balya, the reluctant leader, once again stepped forward, this time to act as Archbishop of Uganda.

THE SUNSET YEARS

At the noble age of 83, Balya finally laid down his staff and retired to his home at Bunyonyi-Kihumuro. But "retirement" was hardly the right word for him. He continued preaching at the small church he had founded back in 1915, mentoring young pastors, and visiting nearby congregations to offer encouragement.

Even in old age, his spirit burned bright. His sermons were shorter now, his steps slower, but his message remained as sharp and radiant as ever: "Serve God faithfully. Love one another. Walk humbly, even if your feet touch the dust."

A MAN OF PRAYER AND SCRIPTURE

Balya's day always began before sunrise. Between 5:00am and

6:00am, he would beat his little drum of prayer, a daily alarm for heaven and household alike. "Nothing," he said, "should come before the praise of God." He prayed often and read the Bible like a man reading letters from a dear friend. His favourite verses were Psalm 23, Psalm 119:105: "Your word is a lamp to my feet and a light to my path," 1 Corinthians 1:26, and Romans 15:20. These were not just words to him; they were walking sticks on his long journey of faith.

DEATH OF A SAINTLY MAN

The old bishop lived long enough to see Uganda change hands, governments and generations. But even time itself seemed to step gently around him.

On the morning of November 26, 1979, at the astonishing age of 102, Bishop Balya breathed his last, just as he had foretold.

His daughter, Elizabeth Mayombo Balya, who was then a Senior Four student, remembers it vividly: "He used to tell us he would not live beyond that year. He said he was going on a long journey to a far place, one he would not return from." That morning, around 7:30am, surrounded by his family, he slipped peacefully away.

On November 30, 1979, Uganda gathered to lay its barefoot bishop to rest. In recognition of his stature, the Government, under president Godfrey Binaisa, granted Balya a state funeral, an honour reserved for the most distinguished sons of the land.

BISHOP BALYA'S FAMILY

Behind the great bishop stood a strong and loving family that shared in his faith-filled journey. In 1907, Bishop Balya married Ketura, his devoted partner, until her passing in 1952. Together, they were blessed with several children: Sam Oyo, Dorothy Nyakairu, Steven Kantu, Eric Kasoma, Clovice Winyi, Marjorie Kulubya, Paul Kamba, Enid Byaruhanga and Apollo Mukindo. After Ketura's death, he found companionship again and married Asta in 1959. The union was blessed with two children, Elizabeth Mayombo and Ronnie Kihumuro Balya, who went on to serve as Uganda's Ambassador to southern Sudan.

Though many of Balya's children have since passed on, his legacy endures through his two surviving children, Elizabeth Mayombo Balya and Ronnie Kihumuro Balya.